

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Illuminated: A Cinematic Journey to Deeper Spirituality
Overcoming Success*

January 19th, 2025



TBD

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on HYMN TO JOY and LANCASHIRE

Meditation on LIFT EVERY VOICE (arr. C. Bull)

WADE IN THE WATER (Spiritual, arr. C. Bull)

Meditation on PRECIOUS LORD (arr. C. Bull)

Fugue in G Major "Gigue", BWV 577 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

As God Imagined (B.E. Boykin) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

A deep and wonderful holiness abides
both in the farthest reaches of the oceans,
and here in the midst of our hearts and minds.
May we feel its presence among us this day.

*May we share the grace and goodness of this day
in this season of Epiphany as together,
we continue on a journey to the peace we need,
for the days to come.*

And as we listen, sing, and pray,
may we feel the power of our own journeys;
the love that guides our way,
the openness of the possibilities,
the hope that call us forward
from familiar places
into what might be.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Womb of Life, and Source of Being

ODE TO JOY

Womb of life, and source of being, home of every restless heart,
In your arms the worlds awakened, you have loved us from the start.

We, your children, gather 'round you, at the table you prepare.
Sharing stories, tears, and laughter, we are nurtured by your care.
Word in flesh, our brother Jesus, born to bring us second birth,
You have come to stand beside us, knowing weakness, knowing earth.
One who shares our human struggles, Life of Life, and Death of Death,
Risen Christ, come stand among us, send the Spirit by your breath.

Brooding Spirit, move among us, be our partner, be our friend.
When our memory fails, remind us who we are, what we intend.
Labor with us, add the birthing of the new world yet to be,
Free of servant, lord, and master, free for love and unity.

Mother, Brother, Holy Partner, Father, Spirit, Only One:
We would praise your name forever, one-in-three, and three-in-one.
We would share your life, your passion, share your word of world made new,
Ever singing, ever praising, one with all, and one with you.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

O God of Wisdom,
you speak creation into being with a word
and call us to listen in the silence for your still small voice.
Come, Holy One, and teach us the ways of freedom.

O God of Might,
you act with strength to save all who suffer
and call us to join your struggle for liberation.
Come, Holy One, and teach us the ways of justice.

O God of Roots and Wings,
you invite us into a boundless family of faith
and call us to embody that same welcome to others.
Come, Holy One, and teach us the ways of hospitality.

O God of Guidance,
you ask us to remember that true success comes
to those who follow the way of love.
Come, Holy One, and teach us the ways of love.

Both on this day and in all the days to come,
help us dream your dreams for a reimagined future,
filled with the best life we can offer to others,
and to ourselves.

[WJaminson/adptlvf]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Shed A Little Light"
Cathedral Choir

JAMES TAYLOR, arr. DAVID HARRIS

***The Lord's Prayer**

Toni Delliquadri

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Each week as we gather in this sacred moment in time,
we listen through the voices of all who struggle
to find ways to embrace a spirit of generosity
that will lead us to true and lasting justice and peace.

We are learning that we need your strength
to let go of our need for outward success,
and as we let go, share what we have with others
so that all may have enough.

This practice continues to help us discover the joy that comes
with welcoming our neighbors to this journey we share,
as we embody the power of the transforming peace
of the Divine. [W]Jamison/adpt/lvf]

Today and in all the days to come,
may this transforming peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Toni Delliquadri

from the Gospel of Mark

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

*In this time of silence you are invited to write the prayers of your heart,
and the prayers that you hold for the world, on the slips of paper in your programs.*

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Each day, God, you help us to walk by the light we know as day.
This light allows us our lives,
it gives us the opportunity to enjoy this beautiful world.
We accept it as gift, God.

Yet another light though,
with deeper purpose,
burns within us.

We know that it draws us both into the world
and into seclusion.
It connects us to each other
and builds our individuality.
It is essential to our lives.

As we share this road, God,
we ask that we might light the way for one another
and, in so doing,
illuminate the truth of the beauty,
which is the life we walk.

*We pray this as those born with the light within us,
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

"This Little Light Of Mine"
Cathedral Choir, Christin Byrdsong, *Soloist*

MOSES HOGAN

Sermon

Overcoming Success

Rev. Michael Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"I Got A Home In-a Dat Rock"
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

STACEY GIBBS

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Toni Delliquadri

Holy One,
today we bring our gifts and we ask that you will give us
the strength to let go of them,
to deliver them generously,
holding nothing back,
in the trust that your gifts to us
are unending and rich beyond
anything we could imagine.

We commit on this day,
to co-creating all of this and more with you,
in honor of the One whose life was and is, a gift.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Lehman

When hope invites us to journey
elusive, beckoning onward
but never in our grasp:
God of wisdom and light,
give us courage to travel on.

When dreams glimmer in the distance,
fading, clouded and hidden,
or shining with new brightness:
God of wisdom and light,
give us courage to travel on.

When established patterns collapse
into the uncertainty of the unknown
and security dissolves into a memory:
God of wisdom and light,
give us courage to travel on.

When the illusion of success
threatens to divert us
and silence our souls' yearning:
*God of wisdom and light,
give us courage to travel on.*
When we think our journey has ended
in the star-lit glow, only to find
the end is a new beginning:
*God of wisdom and light,
give us courage to travel on.*

[JBerry/ssb/lvf]

May it be so.
*May it be so for us now,
and in all the days to come!*

Choral Response

"Walk In Beauty, Walk In Light"
Cathedral Choir, Anna Caplan, *Soloist*

JUDY A. ROSE

*Hymn for the Journey

Bless Now, O God, the Journey

LANCASHIRE

Bless now, O God, the journey that all your people make,
The path through noise and silence, the way of give and take.
The trail is found in desert and winds the mountain round,
Then leads beside still waters, the road where grace is found.

Bless sojourners and pilgrims who share this winding way,
Whose hope burns through the terrors, whose love sustains the day.
We yearn for holy freedom while often we are bound.
Together we are seeking the road where grace is found.

Divine Eternal Lover, you meet us on the road.
We wait for lands of promise where milk and honey flow.
But waiting not for places, you meet us all around.
Our covenant is written on roads, where grace is found.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
As God Imagined - Reprise (Brittney Elizabeth Boykin)

Inside The Music

"This weekend we honor the life and work of Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. His work was surrounded by the music of Negro Spirituals, and so we will sing two as a reflection on his legacy. Spirituals in the canonic sense are a folk music in that their specific authorship is unknown, and they became an integrated part of a broad culture such that people "just knew them." Other musical elements point to their folk origins like the proliferation of the pentatonic scale, and the interchangeability of lyrics and musical motifs across the genre. The late 19th century saw a reclaiming and classicalization of the Negro Spirituals that elevated them and their creators into a potent and universal musical force. The first people to bring them forward did so through a European classical lens. Most were college educated cultural leaders, though their parents had been enslaved a generation before. The broader descendants

of the Spirituals' original creators also reclaimed them in time, remaking them in various idioms from gospel to doowop, eventually hip hop, etc. The Spirituals are unique to folk music, in that the people who set them to music rarely use the arranger attribution. Although "This Little Light Of Mine" has been set by likely hundreds of people, we say that it is Moses Hogan's piece in the context of today. There's a poetry to that practice that I have yet to fully understand. The movie for this week, "Faces Places," features a form of folk art. The young photographer at the center of the film takes photos of everyday people. By putting their likeness into a new context, he offers a mirror for them and their communities. Folk art's apparent ubiquity blended with its simple commentary on the life of a people brings us into a place of core understanding. Moses Hogan's "This Little Light Of Mine" lands like the larger-than-life images on the walls of small towns in France found in "Faces Places." It is a mirror for us. It opens with the choir singing a soft, rhythmically pointilistic, and harmonically rich background texture. A soloist floats above this churning energy with simplicity. The power of the text's clarity rings out over the morass of life: "I have but one light, and I'm going to make sure it shines no matter what." In the third verse, he gives the words to the choir. Their articulation shifts from the smooth "ooo" of the opening verses into a weighty, accented emphasis. During this brief moment, he offsets the lines with idiomatic gospel gestures of the mid 20th Century like soprano "hallelujahs" and leading bass lines. He does so ever so slightly out of context such that we are forced to hear them differently. They aren't the spontaneous expression of a moment that so commonly gives rise to these gestures in the original style. Rather, they are premeditated, chosen, and determined. "My God gave me this light, so I'm going to ensure its brightness." During the Civil Rights Era, "This Little Light Of Mine" became a persistent anthem of struggle. At protests and group meetings people would create new verses to reflect the needs of the moment. A favorite of mine, being from Alabama, is "Tell Ole Gov'nor Wallace, I'm gonna let it shine," but there are dozens of them lost to time. Hogan ends his piece with a nod to this practice. The music abruptly leaves the choir's moment of emphasis, folding back into the subtlety of their "ooo" as the soloist reclaims the space. He says "In my home, all over the world, I'm gonna let it shine." Neither of these are typical verses, yet they point to one of the essential truths of love and light. The light, as an expression of love, begins with the self. From our place of self love, we can shine light into the world. From our little light, we have the capacity to brighten more people and places than we can imagine. As a white child in the 1970s South, this was one of the first songs I remember knowing. The Movement was still in people's living memory, and somehow, this Spiritual that had been a clarion call of the Movement found its way into the ears and hearts of white kids in the very place that had fought so hard to keep the voices of Black Americans from being heard. Such a little light changed how I, and countless others of my generation, saw the world from a young age. Although I had no idea at the time, my soul was bearing the legacy through song that Dr. King had lived and died to ensure. As one of our community said to me last week, in this time, we have the radical capacity to create beauty and share love. We are that community. We have the guidance and inspiration of trailblazers like Dr. King. We have the creativity, curiosity, and compassion essential to make a difference with the light that has been entrusted to us for this time. It will appear the way real justice reform has always appeared: through the comingling of loving determination and perseverance toward a determined future. "Hallelujah!"

~ Dr. David Harris